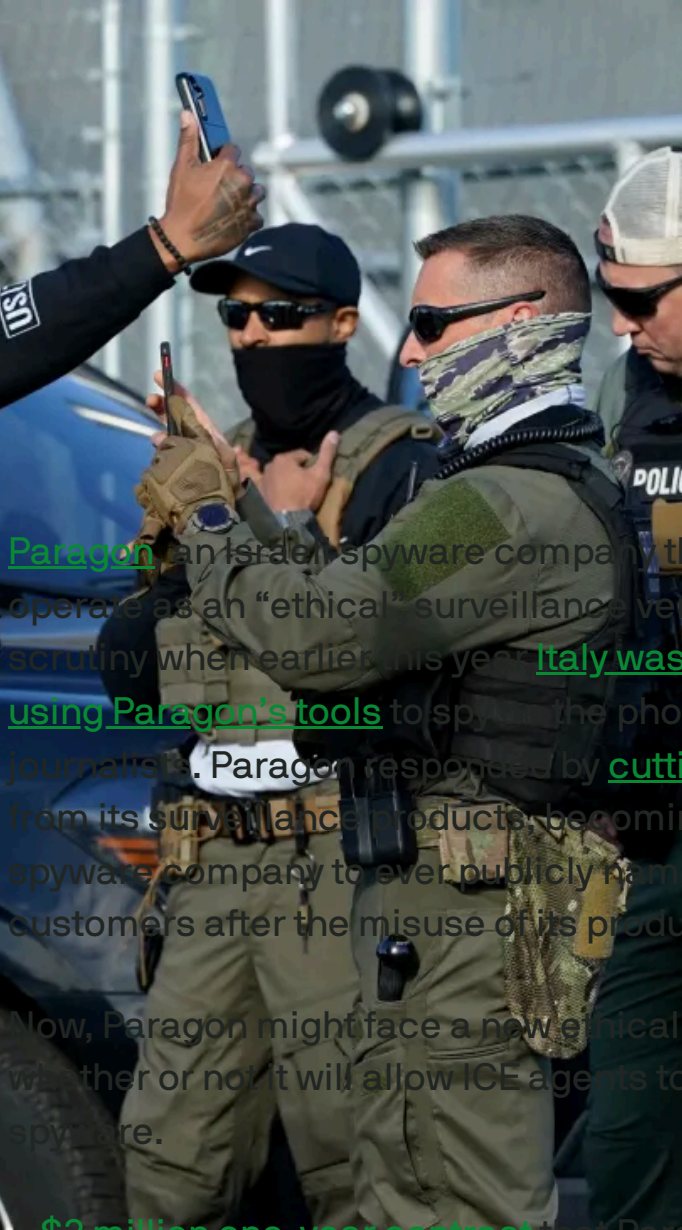


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SECURITY



Can an ‘ethical’ spyware maker justify providing its tech to ICE?



Lorenzo Franceschi-
Bicchierai

— 2:00 PM PDT · July 11,
2025

[Paragon](#), an Israeli spyware company that claims to operate as an “ethical” surveillance vendor, faced scrutiny when earlier this year [Italy was caught using Paragon’s tools](#) to spy on the phones of two journalists. Paragon responded by [cutting Italy off](#) from its surveillance products, becoming the first spyware company to ever publicly name one of its customers after the misuse of its products.

Now, Paragon might face a new ethical dilemma: whether or not it will allow ICE agents to use its spyware.

[A \\$2 million one-year contract](#) that Paragon signed in September 2024 with U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) remains under review and has not yet taken effect, and Paragon has so far not supplied ICE’s Homeland Security Investigations with its spyware tools, the company told TechCrunch.

Since taking office in January, the Trump administration has authorized ICE to carry out large-scale immigration raids across the U.S., leading to the detention of thousands of migrants — and numerous U.S. citizens — in part [thanks to data stored in federal databases](#) and using [technology provided](#) by govtech giant [Palantir](#). Considering ICE is poised to get [a significantly larger budget](#) following the passing of Trump’s flagship Big Beautiful Bill Act into law, spyware could serve as a powerful surveillance tool in the Trump

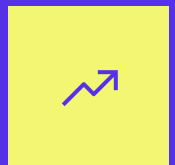
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administration's immigration enforcement operations.

With two months left before the contract expires, Paragon may never supply its spyware to ICE. But until the contract runs out on September 29, the U.S. government could approve it at any moment, forcing Paragon to make a decision about the use of its tools on U.S. soil.

Right now, the company doesn't want to talk about this dilemma at all. When asked by TechCrunch, Paragon would not say what it plans to do if the contract passes review, or clarify what will happen with its relationship with ICE if the contract goes forward.

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Do you have more information about Paragon? From a non-work device, you can contact Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai securely on Signal at +1 917 257 1382, or via Telegram and Keybase @lorenzofb, or [email](#). You also can contact TechCrunch via [SecureDrop](#).

Paragon's contract with ICE has been on pause since the paperwork was signed. Homeland Security issued a near-immediate stop-work order with the goal of reviewing whether the contract complied with [a Biden-era executive order](#). The order restricts U.S. government agencies from using commercial spyware that could (or has been) abused by foreign governments to violate human rights, or to target Americans abroad.

At the time, [a Biden administration official told Wired](#) that the U.S. government had "immediately engaged" top leadership at Homeland Security,

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which houses ICE, to determine if the contract met the requirements of the executive order.

Nine months on, Paragon's contract with ICE remains in limbo, and officials in the Trump White House did not have an update on its status.

Trump administration spokesperson Abigail Jackson referred TechCrunch's questions to Homeland Security, and would not comment, when asked, about the Trump administration's position on the Biden-era spyware executive order, which remains in effect.

A spokesperson for Homeland Security and ICE did not provide comment when contacted by TechCrunch.

Spyware companies have historically been reticent to name their customers in any context, often for fear of reputational damage or risking lucrative government contracts. After [WhatsApp revealed earlier this year](#) that around 90 of its users, including journalists and human rights dissidents, had been targeted with Paragon's spyware, the company sought to distance itself from the hacks. [Paragon's executive chairman John Fleming told TechCrunch](#) then that it only sells to "a select group of global democracies — principally, the United States and its allies."

In other words, Paragon wanted the world to know that it would sell to responsible government customers, and its response to the Italy scandal appears to reinforce the company's position.

But in calling itself an ethical spyware vendor, Paragon has put the onus on itself to judge who it deals with. In doing so, the company has also opened the door for others to scrutinize its government customers and their ethics — whether they are the Italian government or ICE. As

governments and their leaders change over time, Paragon may face the choice of having to re-evaluate who it works with.

“Given this administration’s record of attacks on human rights and civil society organizations, we hope that Paragon would reconsider the agreement,” said Michael De Dora, the U.S. advocacy manager at Access Now, a nonprofit that has worked to expose spyware abuses.

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Researchers confirm two journalists were hacked with Paragon spyware

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

— 5:00 AM PDT · June 12, 2025

Two European journalists were hacked using [government spyware](#) made by Israeli surveillance tech provider Paragon, new research has confirmed.

On Thursday, digital rights group [The Citizen Lab](#) published a new report detailing the results of a new forensic investigation into the iPhones of Italian journalist [Ciro Pellegrino](#) and an unnamed “prominent” European journalist. The researchers said both journalists were hacked by the same [Paragon](#) customer, based on evidence found on the two journalists’ devices.

Until now, there was no evidence that Pellegrino, who works for [online news website Fanpage](#), had been either targeted or hacked with Paragon spyware. [When he was alerted by Apple at the end of April](#), the notification referred to a mercenary spyware attack, but did not specifically mention Paragon, nor whether his phone had been infected with the spyware.

The confirmation of the first-ever known Paragon infections further deepens an ongoing spyware

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scandal that, for now, appears to be mostly focused on the use of spyware by the Italian government, but could expand to include other countries in Europe.

These new revelations come months after [WhatsApp first notified around 90 of its users](#) in over two dozen countries in Europe and beyond, including journalists, that they had been targeted with Paragon spyware, known as Graphite. Among those targeted were several Italians, [including Pellegrino's colleague and Fanpage director Francesco Cancellato](#), as well as nonprofit workers who help rescue migrants at sea.

Last week, Italy's parliamentary committee known as COPASIR, which oversees the country's intelligence agencies' activities, [published a report that said it found no evidence that Cancellato was spied on](#). The report, which confirmed that Italy's internal and external intelligence agencies AISI and AISE were Paragon customers, made no mention of Pellegrino.

The Citizen Lab's new report puts into question COPASIR's conclusions.

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“A week ago it seemed like Italy was putting this scandal to bed. Now they’ll have to reckon with new forensic evidence,” John Scott-Railton, a senior researcher at The Citizen Lab, told TechCrunch ahead of the report’s publication. “Ciro’s case adds to the big and politically tricky question: Who has been hacking Italian journalists with Paragon spyware? This mystery needs an answer.”

Scott-Railton said The Citizen Lab believes that the Italian government is in a position to definitively answer questions about what was done with their use of Paragon spyware, particularly regarding Ciro’s case.

Pellegrino told TechCrunch that he believes that his civil rights have been “trampled upon.”

“I understand that Prime Minister Meloni is a professional journalist like me (I have been a journalist since 2005, she has since 2006),” Pellegrino told TechCrunch. “Does she care about the rights of this type of workers? Why has she not spent a single word in solidarity with the journalists who have been spied on?”

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Do you have more information about Paragon, and this spyware campaign? From a non-work device, you can contact Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai securely on Signal at +1 917 257 1382, or via Telegram and Keybase [@lorenzofb](#), or [email](#). You also can contact TechCrunch via [SecureDrop](#).

After Cancellato revealed he had been targeted with spyware, [the Italian government published a press release](#) denying it was behind the targeting of any journalist or human rights activists.

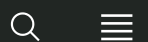
The fact that both Cancellato and Pellegrino work for the same outlet suggests they may be part of a “cluster” of targets, according to the Citizen Lab report.

Pellegrino said that he did not work on the blockbuster Fanpage investigation into the “Gioventù Meloniana,” a group part of Meloni’s Fratelli d’Italia party, which revealed that some of its members sympathize with fascism. Pellegrino, who is the head of Fanpage’s Naples bureau, also said he hasn’t worked on any investigation about immigration.

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disclosed by two other journalists in recent weeks.”

Apart from Pellegrino, another journalist in Italy, Monica Macchioni, said in early May that [she had received a notification from Apple](#). It’s likely that COPASIR is referring to her as the second journalist.

Referring to an email TechCrunch sent to Paragon and its executive chairman John Fleming, Emily Horne, who works for WestExec Advisors, said the spyware maker “won’t have anything new on this,” apart from [what the company said earlier this week](#). At the time, Paragon told [Israeli newspaper Haaretz](#) that it offered the Italian government help to investigate Cancellato’s alleged hack, but the government refused — and that’s why the company cut ties with Italy.

New forensic evidence emerges

On April 29, 2025, the prominent European journalist received a notification from Apple, the same notification that Pellegrino received and on the same day, according to The Citizen Lab. The lab’s researchers analyzed the unnamed journalist’s devices and found that one of them was infected with Graphite, based on forensic evidence showing that the spyware communicated with a server that the researchers had previously established with “high confidence” was part of Paragon’s infrastructure.

Citizen Lab said the journalist was hacked with “a sophisticated zero-click attack against the device via iMessage,” based on the researchers finding a specific iMessage account “present in the device

logs around the same time as the phone was communicating with the Paragon server.”

[Zero-click hacks](#) are some of the most effective attacks, given that, as the name suggests, they require no interaction from the target. And in this case, The Citizen Lab said it believed the attack was invisible to the victim.

According to the report, Apple told The Citizen Lab that “the attack deployed in these cases was mitigated in iOS 18.3.1,” which was [released on February 10, 2025](#), some two weeks after WhatsApp notified the targets of Paragon spyware.

Apple did not respond to TechCrunch’s request for comment prior to publication.

In the case of Pellegrino, The Citizen Lab said it found the same iMessage account on his iPhone’s logs. Given that it’s typical for each government customer to have its own spyware infrastructure, The Citizen Lab said it believed Pellegrino and the unnamed journalist were likely targeted by the same Paragon operator.

The unnamed journalist’s iPhone was infected in January and early February, said The Citizen Lab.

According to COPASIR’s report, Paragon and its Italian intelligence customers suspended the company’s surveillance systems on February 14, 2025, which means that the spy agencies AISE and AISI were still using Paragon’s spyware when the prominent European journalist was hacked.

For now, The Citizen Lab has not attributed Pellegrino’s and the other unnamed European journalist’s hacks to any government.

The Citizen Lab noted in the report that it’s possible some of the people who were notified of having been targeted with Graphite by WhatsApp may also

have been infected, but, due to the fact that Android has limited logs, as well as “efforts by Paragon to delete traces of the infection,” it may be impossible to confirm that.

Other Graphite victims identified

Apart from Pellegrino and the unnamed journalists, two other people have so far been confirmed to have been targeted with Paragon’s spyware: [Luca Casarini](#) and [Beppe Caccia](#), who both work for the Italian nonprofit [Mediterranea Saving Humans](#), which rescues immigrants who try to cross the Mediterranean Sea. The Citizen Lab confirmed both were infected after analyzing their devices. In its report, COPASIR confirmed the two were surveilled by Italian spy agencies.

There are other people who have said they received notifications of having been targeted. Their cases, however, are still somewhat unclear.

David Yambio, a Sudanese citizen and president and co-founder of [Refugees in Libya](#), a nonprofit organization active in Italy that works on immigration issues, received a notification from Apple. After analyzing his device, The Citizen Lab said it found traces of a spyware infection, but could not link the compromise to a particular spyware maker nor any government.

COPASIR said Yambio was lawfully targeted by Italian intelligence agencies, but not with Graphite. COPASIR added that Yambio was under surveillance by the country’s judicial authorities for a criminal investigation. Yambio’s phone was registered to Mattia Ferrari, a priest who collaborates with Mediterranea.

Ferrari also received the spyware notification from WhatsApp. COPASIR, however, said it found no evidence he was targeted with Graphite.

Scott-Railton said that The Citizen Lab forensic and technical analyses are ongoing on all cases, including Cancellato.

Updated on Thursday with a response from COPASIR, and to clarify the second journalist the committee was likely referring to.

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Paragon says it canceled contracts with Italy over government's refusal to investigate spyware attack on journalist

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

— 11:09 AM PDT · June 9, 2025

Spyware maker Paragon accused the Italian government of refusing its help in investigating whether a journalist was spied on with its technology, according to a statement on Monday.

In the statement [first reported by Haaretz](#), Paragon claimed it was this refusal that prompted the company to cut ties with its Italian government customers.

“The company offered both the Italian government and parliament a way to determine whether its system had been used against the journalist in violation of Italian law and the contractual terms,” read the statement. “As the Italian authorities chose not to proceed with this solution, Paragon terminated its contracts in Italy.”

Paragon confirmed to TechCrunch that the statement was accurate. After TechCrunch contacted Paragon’s executive chairman John

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Fleming for comment, Emily Horne, who works for WestExec Advisors, responded saying the company is “referring all media queries” to the statements in the Haaretz article.

This is the first time a spyware provider has publicly stated it cut ties with a specific customer after reports of abuse.

The spyware maker’s accusation is the latest twist in a scandal that erupted in January, when WhatsApp [revealed a mass-hacking campaign](#) targeting its users. The messaging app giant said it alerted around 90 users that they were targeted with spyware made by Paragon, a company co-founded by former Israeli prime minister Ehud Barak (pictured). Paragon, [which has a contract](#) with U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement, has marketed itself in the U.S. and Europe as ostensibly a more responsible vendor compared to its predecessors in the industry.

Francesco Cancellato, the director of news website Fanpage who [was the first person to come forward saying he received WhatsApp’s notification](#), is the journalist that Paragon referred to in the statement.

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Paragon’s statement is a response to [a report](#) published last week by an Italian parliamentary

committee known as COPASIR, which investigated the spyware scandal in the country. The committee concluded there was no evidence that Cancellato had been a target of Italy's two intelligence agencies, AISI and AISE, which it confirmed were Paragon customers.

Hours after Haaretz published Paragon's statement, the Italian government rebuffed Paragon's remarks, saying that the decision to first suspend and then terminate the contract with Paragon was mutual, according to unnamed sources [quoted by Italian news wire ANSA](#).

The sources were also quoted as saying that the Department of Information for Security ([DIS](#)), the Italian government body overseeing AISE and AISI, refused Paragon's help to check the logs on the agencies' Graphite spyware systems because doing so would have exposed confidential data to a private foreign company and compromised national security. Allowing Paragon to help, the sources claimed, would have compromised the reputation of Italian intelligence agencies among its international peers.

COPASIR and the Italian government, which is led by Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni, did not respond to TechCrunch's requests for comment.

Cancellato responded to Paragon's statement [in a video posted on Fanpage](#). "Who is lying in this story? COPASIR or Paragon?" he said.

"To find out, all we have to do is ask Paragon to officially tell us who spied on Fanpage. They said they can find out? We want them to tell us once and for all," said Cancellato.

In late April, Fanpage reporter Ciro Pellegrino [said he had received a notification from Apple](#) that he had been targeted with government spyware.

COPASIR's investigation did not mention Pellegrino's case.

COPASIR, on the other hand, confirmed that other victims of Paragon spyware were lawfully targeted, including [Luca Casarini](#) and [Beppe Caccia](#), who work for the Italian nonprofit [Mediterranea Saving Humans](#), which rescues immigrants who try to cross the Mediterranean Sea, and [David Yambio](#), the president and co-founder of [Refugees in Libya](#), a non-governmental organization active in Italy.

All of them, COPASIR said, were lawfully investigated for their activities related to alleged illegal immigration.

On the other hand, COPASIR concluded that there was no evidence of surveillance against [Mattia Ferrari](#), a priest who works on the rescue ship of [Mediterranea Saving Humans](#), who also received a notification from WhatsApp.

In a [statement to ANSA](#) on Monday, COPASIR said that it was willing to declassify the contents of the hearing it held with Paragon representatives on April 9 to defend its work in the inquiry. The statement said COPASIR was surprised by Paragon's statement.

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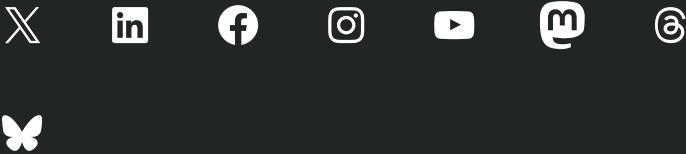
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